

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

FREE

AI Literacy • Lesson 1 of 6

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON

How to Talk to AI

AI grants what you SAID,
not what you MEANT.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



STUDENT SESSION

Cursed Wish Repair Shop



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

The genie's one rule: it grants exactly what you SAY — never what you MEANT. A **cursed wish** is one the genie can twist. A **genie-proof** wish can't be twisted. Genie-proof every wish with all three **P.R.O.** parts:

- **P — Purpose:** what you want + who it's for
- **R — Requirements:** the rules — length, tone, format, what to include or leave out
- **O — Output:** what the finished answer should look like (a list? a table? a paragraph?)



CURSED WISH #1 — AMARA'S SPACE POSTER

Amara's science poster is due Friday. She typed *"tell me about space"* — and got 40 pages on the history of NASA. Rewrite her wish so the genie can't get it wrong. Use P, R and O:



CURSED WISH #2 — MATEO'S HEADPHONE FUND

Mateo gets \$15 a week and wants \$120 headphones. He typed *"help me save money"* — the genie answered: "Stop buying things." Rewrite his wish. Use P, R and O:



CURSED WISH #3 — YUKI'S HERO STORY

Yuki wants an anime-style story for the class magazine. She typed *"make a story about a hero"* — the genie wrote: "Once there was a hero. The end." Rewrite her wish. Use P, R and O:

FOR THE TEACHER

Teacher Guide & Answer Key



How to Talk to AI — improv tips, a key for every student item, what-ifs, the AI-honesty discussion.

WHY THIS LESSON

Every AI job runs **human** → **AI** → **human**: a person starts it (the prompt) and a person ends it (the check). Those two human jobs are the whole skill, and they transfer to every AI tool. This lesson trains both: P.R.O. is the start; the trickster-genie habit is the end. It stands alone — nothing depends on another lesson.

PLAYING THE WORST GENIE EVER

Three moves cover every wish: **take a word literally** ("rich" = a name), **fill the missing detail** (money = play money), or **grant it in the least useful form** (a hero story = "Once there was a hero who end."). Stay cheerful — the genie is never mean, just maddeningly literal. The gold moment when a student adds a rule and you have to grant it properly: applaud it.

SAMPLE GENIE-PROOF REPAIRS (WORKSHEET P.1)

There is no single right answer — score with the Genie-Proof Checklist. Exemplars, with the twist each one blocks:

CURSED	EXEMPLAR REPAIR
Amara — "tell me about space" Twist it blocked: 40 pages	"I'm a 7th grader making a one-page science poster about black holes, due Friday. Give me 5 amazing facts, each under 20 words, written so a 5th grader could get it. No math formulas."
Mateo — "I want to save money" Twist it blocked: "Stop buying things."	"I'm 12 and get \$15 a week. I want \$120 headphones in 10 weeks. Make a simple weekly savings plan as a table, and give 2 tips for not spending it on snacks."
Yuki — "make a story about a hero" Twist it blocked: a one-line story	"Write the opening paragraph (max 100 words) of an anime-style story about a shy kid whose sketchbook drawings come to life. Mysterious tone, end on a cliffhanger."

MODEL TWISTS (KEY FOR THE BREAK-IT PAGE)

A twist counts only if it obeys *every word* of the repaired wish. Two per exemplar — **Amara**: no "under 20 words" → each fact is a page; no "poster" → a 10-page report. **Mateo**: no time limit → a 40-year plan, 6 cents a week; no "simple" → a 30-column spreadsheet. **Yuki**: no length → one sentence again; no "anime-style" → a Western.

SCORING GUIDANCE (EACH REPAIR)

- **Proficient**: all three P.R.O. parts present and specific; partner-genie couldn't twist it.
- **Developing**: two parts, or vague ones ("make it short").
- **Beginning**: restated the cursed wish with more words.

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • LESSON 1 OF 6

How to Talk to AI



45 minutes, no prep. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants what you SAID, not what you MEANT. Students learn both human jobs in every AI task: the prompt and the check. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (2 pages, 1 per student; typeable PDF included) • Slides (optional) • board for P.R.O. • Teacher Guide (Scoring Guidance, P.R.O. sentence starters) • pens	None — runs fully unplugged. Optional: a projector for the slides; one AI tool on your screen for the Showcase	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.3.b

CCSS ELA W.6.4

- Explain why the same AI answers a vague prompt worse than a clear one. (*Exit Ticket #1*)
- Apply **P.R.O.** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt. (*Wish repair 1-3; Exit Ticket #1*)
- Evaluate a sample AI answer: find the checkable claim and where to check it. (*Exit Ticket #2*)

♦ WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (8 MIN)

You are a genie who grants wishes *exactly as worded*. Take 3 wishes and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now *Rich*."
 "I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted — a million dollars, in play money."
 "I wish school was over." → "Granted — the school building is now over... there."

Then ask: "Whose fault is that — the genie's, or the wish?" **Bridge:** "AI works like that genie. It doesn't know what you MEANT — it only knows what you SAID. Every AI job goes human, AI, human: you start it with a wish, the genie does the middle, and you check what comes back. Today you get good at both human parts."

What if a wish is inappropriate? Don't play it: "The genie doesn't grant that one. Next wish." Nobody volunteers? Wish first yourself: "I wish for a snack" → "Granted: one grain of rice."

Transition: "So how do you write a wish a genie can't twist? Lawyers figured this out a long time ago."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — PARTS OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (10 MIN)

Lawyers make contracts genie-proof with clauses. Strong prompts have three parts — write **P.R.O.** on the board as you go:

P — Purpose. What you want + who it's for. "Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader" beats "explain photosynthesis."

R — Requirements. The rules: length, tone, format, include / leave out. This is what stops the twist.

O — Output. What should the finished answer look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Watch one get fixed — build the repair on the board, naming each part as you add it. **Cursed wish:** "help with my history essay" → **Genie-proof P.R.O. prompt:** "I'm writing a 7th grade history essay on the printing press. Give me 3 thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write it for me."